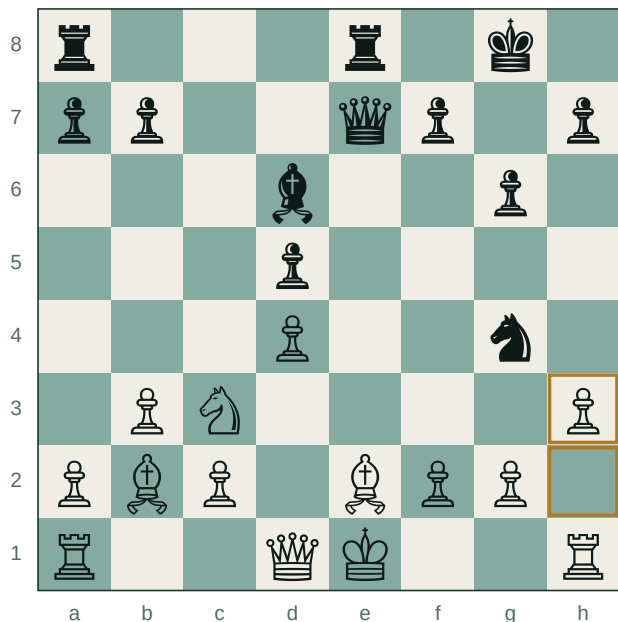


Active defensive resources: Black, move 15

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 15.h3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

15...Nxf2 16. Kxf2 Qe3+ 17. Kf1 Bg3

15...Nxf2 The knight captures the pawn on f2. From f2 it attacks queen on d1 and rook on h1. Recorded reply: **16.Kxf2**.

16...Qe3+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From e3 it attacks king on f2, knight on c3 and bishop on e2. Recorded reply: **17.Kf1**.

17...Bg3 The bishop moves from d6 to g3.

At the end, nominal material is White 34 / Black 28 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -2: the balance goes from -4 to -6. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on e1. Absolute pin: bishop on e2.